

Intro to Human Sciences- Spring 2026

Political Science Module- Lecture 3

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Democracy

Meaning and Interpretation

- Democracy refers to a government based on political equality, i.e. consent is required of all the individuals who form part of the political community. It is informed by the belief that all people are equally capable of, and have a stake in making, collective decisions that shape their lives.
- In a democracy, no one person's opinion or interest is of more value than the other, hence the principle of 'one person one vote'. It is based on the idea of the equal moral worth of all individuals and against the exclusion of anyone from the political process. Thus, it is against hierarchy or inherited privileges and discrimination.
- In a democracy it is assumed that there will be a diversity of opinions and interests on almost every matter of common concern. Indeed, this diversity is seen as its main strength and it calls for tolerance for all shades of opinion.

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- Democratic tradition does not advance a single and agreed ideal of popular rule, but is rather an arena of debate in which the notion of popular rule, and ways in which it can be achieved, is discussed. In that sense, democratic political thought addresses three central questions.
- First, who are the people? As no one would extend political participation to all the people, the question is: on what basis should it be limited – in relation to age, education, gender, social background and so on?
- Second, how should the people rule? This relates not only to the choice between direct and indirect democratic forms, but also to debates about forms of representation and different electoral systems.
- Third, how far should popular rule extend? Should democracy be confined to political life, or should democracy also apply, say, to the family, the workplace, or throughout the economy?

Citizenship

Citizenship is a legal relationship between a state and a citizen.

A citizen is a member of a political community who enjoys the rights and assumes the duties of membership.

The concept of citizenship is composed of three main elements or dimensions (Kymlicka and Norman 2000).

- The first is citizenship as legal status, defined by civil, political and social rights. Here, the citizen is the legal person free to act according to the law and having the right to claim the law's protection. It need not mean that the citizen takes part in the law's formulation, nor does it require that rights be uniform between citizens.
- The second considers citizens specifically as political agents, actively participating in a society's political institutions.
- The third refers to citizenship as membership in a political community that provides a distinct source of identity.

Power

- Robert Dahl (1961) argued that power involved 'A' getting 'B' to do something 'B' would otherwise not do. 'A' can only be understood as being powerful in relation to some other actor.
- What is it that makes 'A' powerful? This question directs us towards the examination of resources and capabilities that are employed by A when getting B to do something they otherwise would have not done. These resources may be many and varied.
- In domestic politics many might argue that power is possessed by those who occupy positions of authority. In International Relations, realists such as Hans Morgenthau have associated military capability with power.
- Joseph Nye has highlighted the importance of 'soft power'. Soft power is the ability to get 'others to want the outcomes that you want', and more particularly 'the ability to achieve goals through attraction rather than coercion'

Authority

- The term authority describes either the right to be obeyed, or the capacity to have one's decision or orders obeyed, without the need of coercion or persuasion.
- The crucial distinction between power in general and authority in particular is that authority is not dependent upon the use of threats or incentives.
- Thus a thief armed with gun may threaten a person or force them to give up their money or a fraudster may use trickery to persuade a person to hand over their cash, but neither of these instances would seem to involve authority.
- Max Weber (1968) identified three different types of authority- Legal-rational, traditional, charismatic

Legitimacy

- Legitimacy is utilised by political actors in justifying their right to govern.
- It consists of two key components- a legal right to authority which is a technical issue and a valid recognition by others of the right to make particular decisions; the former can exist without the latter, as was demonstrated by the apartheid laws which operated in South Africa.
- The concept of legitimacy in the arena of International relations is crucial in the debates on international ethics and humanitarian intervention.
- The concept of legitimacy loomed large during the 2003 Iraq war, specifically over the rights of United Nations Security Council to use force. The conflict was legitimised by those in favour on the need to disarm Iraq of its weapons of mass destruction, the existence of which was never materialised.